reforms.[10] These actions sap IOs of critical resources and momentum, creating significant roadblocks to progress.

Populists also undermine IOs by creating competing institutions that draw away funding, influence, and participation. These rival organizations dilute the power of established IOs and complicate global governance (Alter and Meunier 2009; Clark 2022). For instance, some populist-led states have opted to support new forums that reflect their narrower national interests, leaving existing IOs to navigate diminished relevance.[11]

Populists frequently disregard IO rules, regulations, and policies, fostering a culture of noncompliance. Such behavior can trigger a domino effect as other states become reluctant to comply, fearing they will be the sole adherents (see Barrett 2003). Under Donald Trump's leadership, for example, the United States flouted WTO rules, which had ripple effects across the global trade regime (Carnegie and Carson 2019). Additionally, populists often exploit IOs' decision-making rules, blocking initiatives or staffing appointments that are unaligned with their interests. They may also replace expert bureaucrats with loyalists, muting the professionalism and expertise needed for IOs to function effectively (Eichengreen 2018; Sasso and Morelli 2021; Bellodi, Morelli, and Vannoni 2024).

International organizations thrive on active member participation. Without state representatives engaging in discussions, contributing expertise, and formulating policy, IOs risk becoming "zombies"—entities that exist in name but lack meaningful influence (Gray 2018). Populists exacerbate this risk by withholding not just effort but also funding. Most IOs rely on member-state contributions, whether providing loans, deploying peacekeepers, or adjudicating disputes. The Trump administration's decision to withdraw US funding from the WHO during the COVID-19 pandemic is a stark example of how financial withdrawal can cripple IO activities. Jair Bolsonaro of Brazil similarly cut funds to an array of IOs promoting environmental cooperation during his tenure as president, including the Amazon Cooperation Treaty Organization.

Another critical resource that populists manipulate is information. IOs depend on accurate data from member states to implement policies and ensure compliance. By withholding or distorting this information, populists hinder IOs' ability to function effectively. For example, populists like Donald Trump and Viktor Orbán have weakened scientific bureaucracies by